

Which are the most popular ice cream flavours in Europe - and who eats the most?

For a long time, vanilla ice cream was Europe's favourite flavour. Now a map shows more people trying new varieties as online trends shake up cone classics.

During the summer, each German gets through around 130 scoops of ice cream.

Spread over the whole season that works out at least one scoop a day. This is the figure calculated by the Federal Association of the German Confectionery Industry for 2024.

Considering the current heat wave, ice-cream sellers are rubbing their hands...

When compared with other European countries, Germany, with consumption of eight litres of ice cream per year, is not exactly near the top of the table. Per-capita ice-cream sales in Poland are said to be almost twice as high, at 16 kilos, according to [data \(source in German\)](#) from the information service of the German Economic Institute from 2021.

After Poland, Sweden has per-capita sales of 10.87 kilos of ice cream. In Spain, 9.65 kilos per person per year are consumed. They are followed by Denmark, Finland, Italy, Greece, France and then Germany. Austria and Switzerland bring up the rear.

Which is Europe's favourite ice-cream flavour?

For a long time, vanilla was the most popular ice-cream flavour in many countries, but more and more new creations and inventive varieties are pushing the classics

aside. The Dubai chocolate trend has probably also helped make pistachio, in every form, more popular.

A list drawn up in 2021 by the professional association Uniteis, the union of Italian ice-cream makers, still showed that the classic flavours in particular were holding their own. According to their figures, vanilla was the most popular flavour, followed by chocolate, stracciatella, strawberry, hazelnut, yoghurt, pistachio, lemon, amarena and salted caramel.

This ranking was based on the first six weeks of ice-cream sales reported by members of the association. No recent ranking is available, Uniteis told Euronews. Whether a new league table will be compiled in 2026 is still up for discussion.

A team of experts from Premier Inn carried out much broader research in 2024, evaluating Google search data for 80 different ice-cream flavours worldwide in order to determine each country's favourite. They found that pistachio and melon in particular have become popular alongside the three standard flavours vanilla, chocolate and strawberry.

However, there has also been criticism of the analysis. Google searches do not necessarily reflect people's purchasing behaviour. The hotel chain's research went viral on the online platform Reddit. Many users there argued that complicated-sounding ice-cream flavours are more likely to be googled than varieties everyone already knows.

Even so, the level of interest in certain flavours can be captured in this way.

Eight litres of ice cream per person

Around eight litres of ice cream a year are eaten by each German, according to the Association of German Branded Ice Cream Manufacturers for 2024. Consumption has stabilised at this level for about a decade; the association speaks of a "consistently high level".

Converted, this means that over the course of the summer each German eats around 115 to 160 scoops of ice cream (with a volume of roughly 50 to 70 millilitres per scoop). In total, 540.8 million litres of ice cream were sold in Germany in 2024, according to data from the Federal Association of the German Confectionery Industry (BDSI). This figure includes not only food retailers but also restaurants, kiosks, sports venues and petrol stations.

Everyday life also clearly shows one particular trend: most ice cream is bought in supermarkets rather than over the counter at an ice-cream parlour. Around one fifth of the volume is accounted for by ice-cream parlours; the rest is industrially produced and sold as household tubs, ice creams on a stick, cones, and ice-cream sandwiches.

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What has Pinocchio got to do with the ice-cream flavour of the year?

The Italian ice-cream makers' association has chosen "Pinocchio" as the ice-cream flavour of the year for 2026: a delicate blend of milk ice cream and strawberry ice cream with grissini dipped in chocolate.

The association's president, Augusto De Pellegrin, who also runs an ice-cream parlour in Kulmbach in Upper Franconia, explained at the announcement in December last year that the name was chosen to mark the 200th birthday of the writer Carlo Collodi. Collodi created the famous wooden puppet whose nose grows when he lies.

The association has also come up with a new flavour for the World Cup: Golden Goal Pecan, an ice cream with pecan nuts, marbled with maple syrup and topped with whole pecans. The North American reference comes via the ingredients: pecans are grown mainly in Texas, while maple syrup is considered Canada's signature product.

Ice cream in Germany still cheap by EU standards

Although other countries consume more ice cream, Germany is among those with the best value for money. Presenting the ice-cream flavour of the year, Uniteis president Augusto De Pellegrin said a scoop in Germany costs on average between €1.80 and €2.50.

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